

ENGLISH *AAJKAL*: HINGLISH IN HINDI CINEMA

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Dhrubo exhaled richly out of the window, and said, 'I've a feeling, August you're going to get hazaar fucked in Madna ... Amazing mix, the English we speak. Hazaar fucked. Urdu and American.' Agastya laughed, 'A thousand fucked, really fucked. I'm sure nowhere else could languages be mixed and spoken with such ease.'

—Upamanyu Chatterjee,
English, August: An Indian Story, 1988

The encounter with Hinglish in most parts of urban India is impossible to escape. In the city of Ahmedabad, which does not represent the 'Hindi-speaking belt' of India, my day begins with substantial doses of Hinglish. As I tune in to the FM radio channels to listen to music, I am subjected first to a radio jockey's cheerful assault: '*Aaj aap apne boyfriend se ek naya gift maangein and uske love ko test karein!*' This is followed by Hinglish songs like '*Zara zara touch me ...*' and statements such as '*Pappu can't dance saala*', surprising, because he has a '*Rado watch and Nike shoes*'. If this typifies the aural experience, the visual signs of '*pure bhi poori bhi*' advertising cooking oil or posters of *Love Aaj Kal* outside multiplexes are equally code-switched.

This essay examines the social meanings surrounding English and Hinglish in Hindi cinema and the continuities and discontinuities running through them in post-Independence Hindi cinema. I argue that during this period Hindi cinema used English with connotations of cultural alienation such as Westernization and class elitism, giving way in the last two decades to a less anxious use of Hinglish—creolized, constructed, and promoted as a language of fun-on-Indian-terms. While the association with class persists, it moves from signifiers of exclusivity to aspiration, as more people are now able to access that class. If the class theme represents continuity, the discontinuity lies in the shift of perception of English from being a language 'outside' the sphere of everyday Indianness (1950s–1980s) to Hinglish as simultaneously Indian-and-global, embracing *des* and *pardes*, nation and diaspora in cinema after the 1990s. Thus the essay runs as a narrative from English to Hinglish, and traces the journey of English from the past to the present, shedding some legacies and acquiring new social meanings. While the part on 'English' refers to the insertion of English words or phrases in the Hindi text of cinema from the 1950s to the 1980s, Hinglish is the code-switched language of mainstream Hindi cinema after the 1990s. The two are not watertight, discrete phenomena; they flow into each other, differentiated here by the social meanings they generate.

The 1990s may be described as a convenient marker to contextualize India's transition from a socialist to a consumerist (and globalized) economy. Among the many subsequent changes, the shift in attitude towards English is perhaps profound. At the same time, such overemphatic periodization runs the risk of a ruptured historiography—too neat a separation of categories before and after the 1990s. The present essay employs this marker but also attempts to diffuse neat categorizations by demonstrating the legacies of class and superiority that continue to be associated with English before and after liberalization, along with a simultaneous increase in comfort at indigenizing English and mixing it with Indian languages.

The first half of this essay focuses on the anxieties surrounding

English in Hindi cinema in the first four decades after Independence. It demonstrates the various, but not mutually exclusive, positions of English as the language of an anglicized elite, of villains and buffoons, and of people who created divisions in homes, communities, nations. These patterns are constructed not so much in terms of a linear history but conjured as forms of signification (at least in my mind). Mapped as a series of dominant patterns associated with English in Hindi cinema, this section is an evocative, non-linear narrative extracted from my memories as a viewer.

The second half discusses, through Hindi cinema, the cultural construction of 'Hinglish' as a language shaped by and shaping the post-1990s generations in contemporary India. In a liberalized India, the media, youth, the middle class, and Hinglish form not just intersecting but constitutive ways of being modern.

It is important to clarify what is meant by the 'Hindi' of Hindi cinema. Sifting through various positions on whether the language of Hindi cinema is 'Hindi' at all, if not Urdu and/or Hindustani, Trivedi (2007: 52) underscores the continuity of the linguistic spectrum that renders the classification of Hindi, Urdu, and Hindustani somewhat tenuous. The linguistic signs in Hindi cinema may point to multiple forms of signification but are identified by the popular notion of 'Hindi'. Whether this Hindi is closer to Persian or to Sanskrit is not critical to this discussion, but suffice it to say that it occupies 'the middle ground of wide intelligibility' (Trivedi 2007: 58). Hereafter, the label 'Hindi' stands for the widely intelligible language of Hindi cinema.

I

During the sultry months of June–July 2007, when I first began to examine the phenomenon of Hinglish, a high point of conversations in India was the appointment of Pratibha Patil as President. The subject was discussed hotly, and arguments thrown back and forth—on talk shows, at *paan* shops, on blogs, at dining tables—on whether Patil deserved to hold that office.

The moral, ethical, and political contexts of such arguments are not germane to what I want to say. However, one of the oft-raised objections expressed by the very young and the old alike was: 'She can't even speak proper English.' The irony of subjecting the nation's President to such a test was lost on Midnight's great-grandchildren who see English as nothing but a *naturally* desirable, Indian language.

This minimum qualification for being Indian and, more important, for representing Indianness, was hardly articulated in so many words. However, it came as something of a fresh development to those of us who have been witnessing the process of English-in-the-making-of-an-Indian-language. We expect our presidents and prime ministers to know English, yet few had understood Jawaharlal Nehru's English address to a newly independent India in 1947. It would appear then, that from 1947 to 2007, our relationship with and competence in English has changed drastically. However, the intervening decades show that it was not really so drastic. English continued to be a part of India's public culture, especially cinema, the primary arena of concern in this essay.

But as in cinema, so in real life, the journey of English was chequered. Elsewhere, I have discussed India's ambivalent relationship with English with regard to language policies; the silence around the subject of the exclusion of English from the official languages of the nation and implicit hope that the postcolonial state would somehow work its way around this problem (Kothari 2006). Cinema, like several other institutions until the 1980s, also reflects this ambivalence and anxiety. I illustrate below the multiple embodiments of English in Hindi cinema—its position, variously, as a language of another nation, class, and people. Manifest variously as an element of divisiveness, collaborator with urbanization and gentrification, and sometimes a source of comedy, English had an uneasy relationship with Hindi cinema.

Growing up, as I did through the 1970s and 1980s, on a heavy diet of Hindi cinema, led me to some inevitable conclusions about the use of English in the films of that period. The cinema

of the 1970s and early 1980s presented English as the language of such 'Westernized' and anglicized minorities as Christians, Anglo-Indians, and Parsis. When the Anglo-Indian Julie (in *Julie*, 1975) strummed the guitar and sang '*My heart is beating, keeps on repeating, I'm waiting for you ...*' it seemed that Anglo-Indians always spoke English, and that you could 'romance' only in English. It was a new way of being in love, and even if we couldn't or didn't want to be Anglo-Indians, English could take us some distance. Anglo-Indians could be substituted by Christians or Parsis, yet the perception persisted that some communities were 'free'—their women could wear short skirts, bring boyfriends home, and sing songs in English.¹ While the component of English in the actual dialogues may have been negligible, English got stereotyped as the language of the anglicized minorities, with its accompanying signifiers of Westernization such as the guitar and frocks, which lingered on in viewers' minds.

To a lesser extent, it also portrayed English as the language of romance. For instance, note the character of Vikram who declares his love for Julie in the popular song:

*Bhool gaya sab kuchh, yaad nahiin ab kuchh
Ek yahi baat na bhooli, Julie, I love you.*

It was not clear then (nor is it now) whether Vikram professed his love in English because Julie is what she is, or because he needed to express his feelings in a language outside the feudal orbit of his upper-caste Bengali Hindu community.² What is important is to see that the two strands—English as a language of certain 'Westernized' minorities, and English as a language of romance—intertwined to form a stereotype. A synonymy between English and particular forms of identity, mostly away from everyday Indian experience, persisted at overt and subtle levels.

Among the films that go into the folklore of families, such as mine, was the famous Raj Kapoor starrer *Shree 420* (1955). The characters of Raju (or Raj) and Vidya belong to the lower middle class, which values education and continuously strives

to improve its living conditions. All conversations between Raj and Vidya or her father, also an educated person and a retired teacher, are in Hindi. English appears as a language of the casino which Raj visits—significantly, through impersonation. Finding himself amidst pretentious millionaires, Raj speaks a mix of Hindustani and English. Meanwhile, the English-speaking stereotype is grafted on to the rich and decadent; a woman with a cigarette greets everybody in a phoney accent—'Hello! You naughty boy'—while another character with French beard, stick, and cigar makes generous use of the stock phrase 'Not a bad idea.' In such films, English assumed a disruptive role by being portrayed as the language of the 'bad' Westernized elite, insensitive to the predicaments of the working class. In the socialist frame of the film, this also indicated the common man's disillusionment with the decadence of the elite.

In the 1970s when I was watching these films, I was also the first of six children in my family to have studied in an English-medium school. Each time I was aloof and stayed away from social gatherings, it was attributed to my English-medium education, a source of some pride, some disapproval. English was a language of divisions, creating wedges between people, families, and nations—a pattern we see across an array of films. The divisiveness of English was at times through the language, at times through characters who spoke the language, making it difficult to separate the agent from the identity of disruption. For instance, the view of English as a disruptive force was extended to 'foreign-returned' relatives in *Purab Aur Paschim* (1970). The 'solution' offered was the taming of such 'outsiders', integrating them into the community, by making them shed cigarettes, dressing more fully and, of course, speaking Hindi. In fact the non-resident Indian's language as well as accent, whether in *PAP* or, almost forty years later, in *Namastey London* (2007) served as a fertile site for certifying 'Indianness'. The difference between Saira Banu's alienation from India in *PAP* and that of Katrina Kaif in *NL* is constructed through the same set of 'Indian' and 'foreign' signifiers.

Noted filmmaker Mahesh Bhatt mentions (in this volume)

that when he joined the industry in the late 1970s, only villains and comedians used English, pointing thereby to yet another pattern. From the most quoted 'villain' Ajit (whose English dialogues pass around now as jokes) to Bob Christo (*Mard*, 1985), English in the late 1970s and 1980s was strongly associated with villains who spoke more English than Hindi. Even their vamp girlfriends, with names such as Rita and Mona, used more English than Hindi—when they *did* speak at all. Their accents, clothes and even backdrops had a touch of exaggeration, marking them as 'outsiders'. If by being villains or vamps, they could not be taken seriously and absorbed into the moral universe of the audience, the comic and light-hearted use of English also ensured their non-seriousness in the narrative.

The comic use is complex, as it entails elements of parody as well as reverence. Songs about teaching and learning English (Kishore Kumar's famous '*C-A-T cat, cat maane billi*') or frivolous references to high life, '*Mera naam Chin Chin Choo ... Hello mister, how do you do?*' in the 1950s or Veeru's inebriation in *Sholay* that leads him to turn Hindi words into 'English' by suffixing '-ing' are non-serious. In such instances, both the English language and the comic speakers who murder it are simultaneously portrayed as objects of ridicule.

This subtext of comedy directed at the English language is particularly pronounced when English appears as a jumble of polysyllabic, pretentious words thrown by the working class in the face of 'English'-knowing people. An example is *Namak Halaal* (1982) where Arjun, on being asked by his sly and villainous employer whether he can speak English, replies that he 'speaks better English than the Angrez themselves'. He demonstrates this through the gibberish: 'I can talk English, I can walk English, I can laugh English, because English is a very funny language. Bhairon becomes Baron and Baron becomes Bhairon because their minds are very narrow.'

If part of the joke is directed at the way Indian names are mutilated in English, some of it is also directed at Bhairon, a villager turned into a meek and pathetic character in a city, a far cry from 'Baron'. English in Hindi cinema often collaborated

with urbanization and contributed to a view that the city has a debilitating influence on those who come from villages.

This joke is followed by a breathless and incomprehensible account of what is essentially a cricket commentary—committed to memory and rendered rapidly with impeccable pronunciation—a subaltern's nonsense thrown at the powerful:

In the year 1929 when India was playing Australia at the Melbourne stadium Vijay Hazare and Vijay Merchant were at the crease. Vijay Merchant told Vijay Hazare, look Vijay Hazare, this is a very prestigious match and we must consider it very prestigiously. We must take this into consideration, the consideration that this is an important match and ultimately this consideration must end in a run.

In the year 1979 when Pakistan was playing against India at the Wankhede Stadium Wasim Raja and Wasim Bari were at the crease and they took the same consideration. Wasim Raja told Wasim Bari, look Wasim Bari, we must consider this consideration and considering that this is an important match we must put this consideration into action and ultimately score a run. And both of them considered the consideration and ran and both of them got out.

In *Amar Akbar Anthony* (1977), Anthony's song '*My name is Anthony Gonsalves*' is nothing but subversive prattle, an erudite verbosity born out of perhaps an incomprehensible English education: 'You see the coefficient of the linear is juxtaposition by the haemoglobin of the atmospheric pressure in the country. *Jisse meri yaad aaye jab chaahe chali aaye, Rupnagar premgali kholi number 420. Excuse me please!*'

The parody of English robs the 'English machine' of its own historicity, its power (perhaps), its legend, its authority. As a cultural memory of a subjugating race, English is given a nod of acknowledgement but also resented enough to evoke jokes. Thus Hindi cinema evoked several interconnected associations of class, Westernization, pretentiousness, power and parody in

the average spectator's mind. However, not all use of English in Hindi cinema draws so much attention to the language; there are instances when English appears without being invested with moral judgement—natural and even with a certain flair.

My enduring memory of such an example is Tariq Ali in *Yaadon Ki Baraat* (1973), who also strums the guitar and calls out, 'E laal kapdon waali memsaab' in the middle of his song. 'Kaun main?' replies someone from the audience; with a flourish, Ali says, 'Of course!' A youthful, romantic film, YKB circulated an image of being young, being centre stage, and being somewhat audacious in a different language. In fact, we see similarly performative elements in the use of Hinglish later.

II

In the decades when cinema showed English-speaking characters as 'outsiders', publishers did not issue vast lists of Indian English fiction, and writing in English evoked mixed feelings of suspicion and admiration. Until the 1980s, an oft-repeated question that Indians writing fiction and poetry in English had to face was why they wrote in English. They had to explain the choice or compulsion of writing in a language that was not perceived as 'authentic' and carried colonial baggage. In seminars and conferences, writers testified to their 'Indianness' of spirit and content. Some, like Kamala Das, stridently defied their anti-English critics:

... Don't write in English, they said.
English is not your mother tongue. Why not leave
Me alone, critics, friends, visiting cousins,
Every one of you? ...

... The language I speak
Becomes mine, its distortions, its queernesses,
All mine, mine alone. It is half English, half
Indian, funny perhaps, but it is honest ...

—Kamala Das, 'An Introduction',
Summer in Calcutta: Fifty Poems, 1965

Meanwhile 'Hindi', one of the two most used ingredients in 'half Indian', was also moving along a complex trajectory. Pitted as the adversary of a Western language such as English or of an allegedly Muslim language such as Urdu, Hindi became a political tool of nationalism from the late nineteenth century onwards. Its idiom was manipulated and a stilted bureaucratic register that formed official Hindi distanced it woefully from spoken Hindi. *Chupke Chupke* (1975) parodies this Hindi, as also the irrational rejection of English. It is after the 1990s that we see Hindi and English, previously pitted against each other as adversaries in years gone by, cohabiting in the cultural landscape of India, and Hinglish becomes a manifestation of this cohabitation. Hinglish constitutes the possibility of taming English, branding upon the outsider of former years an indigenous mark, and having fun and fulfilment in doing so. In addition, it tends to be used extensively by the global and diasporic Indian, who draws on commonly used Hindi expressions in English conversations with other South Asian constituencies in the diaspora. At home, it evokes associations of money, commodities, and freedom to choose, never mind whether the choices are radical or superficial.

In Zoya Akhtar's debut film *Luck by Chance* (2009), a scriptwriter makes a tragi-comic attempt to teach a beautiful but somewhat linguistically and intellectually challenged heroine to enunciate the word *khoon* properly. Exasperated, the scriptwriter substitutes *khoon* with 'murder'. In a Hindi-Urdu script, a smattering of English solves the problem of an actor's linguistic inadequacy. The scriptwriter can take it for granted that a spectator would be familiar with 'murder'. However, this also shows that the audience's lexicon might accommodate the English word 'murder' more easily than the Sanskritized Hindi word '*hatya*', which is in fact a precise equivalent of 'murder' whereas the literal meaning of *khoon* is 'blood', 'murder' being metaphorical. The opening consonant of *khoon* reflects the educated stylistics of an Urdu register that is beyond the reach of a South Bombay urban character played by the heroine. *Hatya* would not be a part of her lexicon either; indeed it would

be a mouthful for a character with a limited linguistic repertoire. Hindi or Urdu, with or without the stylistic enunciation, *khoon* forms a part of common parlance in the vocabulary of Hindi cinema and its patrons, and its quick substitution with an English word shows the easy accessibility of English.

To return to the example from *LBC*, a superficial reading would be to show how the female lead representing elite, urban India suffers from a disconnect with authentic India, by not having bothered to learn the language of the people. However, a judgement of that kind would obfuscate the complex sociological issues surrounding the episode and do injustice to Akhtar's meta-cinematic and ironic comment targeted at the industry of Hindi cinema. The episode points to the people who constitute the upper echelons of Hindi filmdom, who increasingly appear to know less and less Hindi-Urdu. As a generation of scriptwriters and actors fluent in Hindi literary traditions is replaced by English-trained creative personnel, Hindi cannot be taken for granted. Scriptwriter Rekha Nigam mentions how actors in Hindi cinema find it difficult to give interviews, learn dialogues, and read in Hindi. Scriptwriters are reminded to use a mixture of Hindi and English by way of a 'youth lingo' (personal interview, 28 November 2009). The episode also points to another concurrent phenomenon—the familiarity of the audience with certain English words, allowing filmmakers to substitute one language for the other, without worrying about the ideologies that once made English and Hindi adversaries.

The blithe Hindi-English mix in the example from *LBC* does not betray anxieties of the kind we witness in the past, but an accommodation made for the different constituencies that comprise the social reality and market forces driving cinema in contemporary India. The ideologies of colonialism and lack of authenticity that attended English recede in the mix but the ideology of class overlaps with consumerism and is intricately tied in with Hinglish. In her discussion of a new bourgeois public sphere in India, Leela Fernandes (2000) explores a gamut of media messages. She notes that many of them are targeted specifically at the middle class and often characterized 'by a

hybridized language, the mix of Hindi and English'. Not only Hindi and English, but mixing English and Indian languages has come to represent a peculiarly Indian way of being urban, and though the period after the liberal reforms has not created this bilingualism, it has contributed to its legitimacy as a cultural expression. It has arrived at a point where we have stopped creating binaries of an 'Indian' language, which could represent our emotions and 'English' that was the language of our 'intellectual make-up' (Kothari 2006). A song from the 1960s, '*Jodi hamari banega kaise jaani, hum to hain Angrezi, tum ladki Hindustani*' (Aulad, 1968), which spelt out the impossibility of coupling English and Hindi, would seem a quaint problem in the code-switched universe of media today.

The construction of a happy blend is both visible and visual through Hinglish cultural products—films, advertisements, signboards, short text messages, talk shows, T-shirt slogans, social networking sites—promoting in overt and covert ways a lifestyle that allows you to be *desi* and consumerist simultaneously. The austerity of a generation that grew up in the early decades after Independence has given way to a generation that sees no virtue in thrift and self-denial. Consumerism is not embarrassing, but a celebratory part of being Indian. It is vital to understand this phenomenon in the light of the increasing legitimacy of consumerism, evident in the intergenerational shift in the lyrics from Hindi films below:

*Zyaada ka nahiin laalach humko
Thode men guzaara hota hai
(Jis Desh Mein Ganga Behti Hai, 1960)*

*Thoda hai thode kii zaroorat hai
Zindagi yahaan phir bhi khoobsoorat hai
(Khatta Meetha, 1978)*

If you want my love, sure enough *tumhen mil jaayega* . .
If you pay my bill *mera ye dil tera ho jaayega*
Money show me the money, ha ah
If you want romance, *nahiin koi chance*

Unless let's do wanna spend ...
 Emotion's out money is in, *yehi hai* latest trend
 Money show me the money
 If you pay my bill, *mera dil tera ho gaya, yahi hai* latest trend
 Money, show me the money
 (*Apna Sapna Money Money*, 2006)

Songs like these circulate through multiple media, old and new—FM channels, downloads, ringtones, caller tunes. They are loud, audacious, and peppy, some pointing to the pleasures of commodities, some to pleasures of the body as a commodity in its own right. Inseparable from the plethora of the post-1990s 'feel good' films, which also celebrate pretty looks, luxury goods, and a monochromatic view of the 'good life', such songs evoke the imagery that all is well with the world. As far as cinema is concerned, the evidence of an aspiring India lay in the restless protagonists of the post-1990s, yearning to redefine their lives. The opening up of the economy in 1991 signalled, among other things, an ease for the youth in crossing socio-economic barriers. This demographic shift and desire for new self-definition is very often captured through a mix of Hindi and English in cinema. Raring to reject the old self-definitions, this India is hungry for more and sees no reason why it should not be possible.

One of the more successful films of the 1990s, Ram Gopal Varma's *Rangeela* (1995), dealt with this restlessness in the middle class. Made during the early years of a liberalized India, *Rangeela* is the story of Milli, a young middle-class girl and her desire to have more, become more. The theme for 'more-ness' is set at the very beginning—the credits begin with Milli's dream in which she is centre stage, dancing with everybody else following her. The song '*Yai re yai re, zor laga ke nache re*' presages her aspirations through '*bade bade naamon pe apna bhi naam ho ...*' The ambition for distinction and singularity, as the song unfolds, is accompanied with the dilemmas of a child consumer who says:

Cadbury's *bole main meetha hoon*
 Amul *bole main meetha hoon*
 Chocolate *khaane men tension hain*
 Doodh *peene men tension hain*

Milli refuses to fit into the middle-class, predetermined role by announcing to her parents: '*Mujhe parh likh kar clerk nahiin banna.*' Her invocation of a 'clerk' to connote an unproductive life typical of another generation and another time in India has semiotic similarity with the term 'ticket collector' that Bunt (Bunt *Aur Babli*, 2005) uses to reject his father's lifestyle.

Meanwhile, the names of brands and products that make up the child's verse above continue in many later songs, for instance, in the films *Rock On!!* (2008), *Gulaal* (2009) and *Jaane Tu Ya Jaane Na* (2008). '*Yaaro sun lo zara*', another song from *Rangeela*, is peppered with words such as 'TV', 'video', and 'bank balance'—linking technology and money with what came to be seen as the 'good life' in the 1990s. In fact, objects of middle-class desire, names of products, educational degrees and cuisine form a strong base for the Hinglish lexicon. If Hindi helps communicate to larger numbers, the English element provides the aspiration quotient. One helps relate, the other helps buy dreams and commodities.

Not all linguistic practices under the rubric of Hinglish make overt references to money. In a manner where a certain degree of affluence can be taken for granted, films like *Dil Chahta Hai* (2001), *Pyaar Mein Twist* (2005), *Thoda Pyaar Thoda Magic* (2008), *Sorry Bhai* (2008), or more recently, *Love Aaj Kal* (2009) seek a new epistemology of love. Based on the lives of diasporic, global Indians for whom moving from Delhi to San Francisco and back could be a reality, a host of films in Hinglish speak to audiences that do not have to leave homes, learn English, make money, but have them all. They slide into Hindi with apparent unselfconsciousness.

The current status of Hinglish in cinema—and in today's youth—is perhaps best showcased by Imtiaz Ali's *Jab We Met* (2007), a love story set in contemporary India. The film opens

with industrialist Aditya escaping the claustrophobic environment of his boardroom by shedding the trappings of his class—he refuses the services of a chauffeur, abandons his car and even his cellphone, commutes on a local bus, and finally boards a train where he meets Geet, a fellow passenger he later falls in love with.

The film's Hinglish title was the product of an open competition inviting suggestions from the public. Despite the awkward juxtaposition of words, the film deftly constructs Hinglish as the 'natural' language of the girl, Geet, who is nothing if not natural and transparent. Note her choice of words when she relates how she almost missed a train:

Line cross karte karte train pakdi
Mera record hai ki aaj tak meri train nahiin chhooti
Thank you babaji
Mujhe non-A/C mein zyaada achha lagta hai
Lekin meri family kehti hai akeli ladki ko non-A/C mein
travel nahiin karna chaahiye
I mean A/C ka ladki hone se kya matlab hai
And most of all is train se, yeh to mera second home
hai ...

Unlike its predecessors in the 1990s, *Jab We Met* does not employ English or Hinglish as a language of upward mobility. Its presence is taken for granted, and the focus is upon the naturalness of a relationship. While there are unmistakable signs of affluence in *Jab We Met*, the train, youth and Hinglish constitute a sense of being ordinary, everyday, and natural in a youthful way. In such a context, Hinglish acquires a justifiably sunny quality. It would also appear that this is how two young cosmopolitan people from different parts of India would connect, though we know from other essays in this volume that such a generalization cannot be made without qualifications. The branding of Hinglish is being perpetuated through homogenization of differences and by catering to only the metropolitan youth. Baffled by the Hindi text of a letter which mentions, '*Maine azaadi se shaadi kar li hai*', a Delhi-based

young man in the film *Rang De Basanti* (2006) asks, 'Who talks like this now?' People in non-metropolitan centres in India do, but they are not the ones projected as templates for modernity. The Hindi cinema of contemporary India is looking out for one age group, one market, one language—made out of two. Its chequered relation with English of the past remains buried under a celebratory spell of 'this new big thing'.